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Senate of Virginia Floor Session, Wednesday, February 18, 2026

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[00:00:13] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:01:05] Senate chamber.

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[00:02:29] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:03:40] Senate chamber.

[00:04:34] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:07:14] Senate chamber.

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[00:08:48] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, Senate Chamber.

[00:10:55] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, Senate Chamber.

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[00:15:40] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:17:03] Chamber.

[00:17:15] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:19:19] Senate Chamber.

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[00:21:32] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:22:41] Senate Chamber.

[00:23:36] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:25:58] Senate Chamber. Be sure to stay connected with live sessions, catch up on past meetings, and explore our full archives anytime on the Senate of Virginia's YouTube channel. This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia. Chamber. This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia. Senate Chamber. Be sure to stay connected with live sessions, catch up on past meetings, and explore our full archives anytime on the Senate of Virginia's YouTube channel.

[00:34:11] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:35:37] The Senate will come to order.

[00:36:00] The senators, the senators will please take their seats. Those persons not entitled to the privileges of the floor will retire to the gallery. The senators and all in attendance will please stand if you are able. This morning we will be led in prayer by the Reverend Nathan Cecil from Fox Hill Road Baptist Church in Hampton.

[00:36:24] And following the prayer, everyone will please remain standing. We will be led in the Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America by Senate page Olivia Vogel of Falkir. Let's pray. Oh, great God, our Father, maker of heaven and earth, I thank you for this day.

[00:36:44] As these men and women have gathered together to give themselves to their location of leading our state, I pray that you give them a sense of their duty, that they've been given authority from you for the specific purpose of governing those under their care. Make them good stewards of their God-given authority, knowing that you are the one that they will one day give an account to.

[00:37:02] Help them to govern with care and concern for all image-bearing, life-possessing people in our state, regardless of ethnicity, age, or ability. Help them to use their authority to limit evil conduct and to promote good conduct, knowing that they do not bear the sword in vain. Give them sober minds to know that you, by your grace, for your purposes, have given them this authority to rule.

[00:37:23] I also pray you'd give them a sense of their great privilege that is theirs as leaders of this state, knowing that they are representing many who will never step foot in this capital. May they serve and represent their constituents faithfully with integrity. May they not take for granted your kindness that set them here at this place in this time.

[00:37:39] Would you keep them from the pride that would so easily ensnare them and dishonor you? Grant them the supernatural ability to consider others as more significant than themselves. Father, I pray that in these days of conflict and outrage, you'd keep these legislators safe. I pray that not only for them, but also for their families.

[00:37:54] I pray for their spouses and their children, their grandchildren. Would you provide for the needs of their families? Would you keep them from evil? I pray for their marriages. I ask that their calling as legislators would not prevent them from being faithful spouses, parents, or grandparents. And finally, Father, I pray today that you would, by your grace, grant them the joy that comes only from your presence.

[00:38:13] For it is in your presence alone, placed only accessible through the death and resurrection of the Son, that anyone can find fullness of joy. So I pray that you would grant that joy freely and fully to these men and women today and every day from this one forward. And I pray all this in the name of Christ. Amen.

[00:38:29] I pledge allegiance to the flag of the United States of America and to the republic for which it stands. One nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

[00:39:08] The clerk will call the roll. All those present, please vote aye.

[00:39:27] The clerk will close the roll. You have a quorum, Madam President. Senate Journal for Tuesday, February 17, 2026. The Senator from Hampton moves that the reading of the journal be waived.

[00:39:48] All in favor of waiving the reading of the journal will record their votes aye. Those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 33, noes 6.

[00:40:06] Ayes 33, noes 6. The reading of the journal is waived. the clerk will report any communication from the house of delegates the senator from eastern fairfax um good afternoon madame president good afternoon madame president i move to waive the reading of the communication from the house of delegates the question is shall the reading of the communication be waived all in favor of waving the reading of the communication from the house of delegates will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote

[00:40:38] have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll eyes 34 nose 5 eyes 34 nose 5 the reading of the communication is waived the clerk will report any communications from the governor we do not have any madam president the senator from eastern fairfax uh madam president i move to suspend the rules and grant the privileges of the floor to a certain distinguished person the question is shall the rules be suspended and the privileges

[00:41:16] of the floor be granted to a distinguished person. All in favor of that motion will record their votes aye. Those opposed, no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll.

[00:41:35] Ayes 39, noes 0. Ayes 39, noes 0. The privileges of the floor are granted. The chair recognizes the senator from western the senator has the floor thank you chair members of the body with us today is somebody we all know and many of you served with and remember finally Senator Walter Stosh for those of you that don't know for those of you in the gallery he was the senior senator from Henrico County serving from 1992 until 2016 he's got a lot of titles so I'm gonna read them off former senator

[00:42:10] pro tem chairman of Senate Finance majority leader longest-serving CPA in the General Assembly and just as importantly once he retired he co-founded Grasp which many of you know are people who go into our schools and help kids get into college it's a great program and and I'll just end by saying you know the senator and I probably there's a lot of things we don't agree on politically but what but I'll tell you what there is one thing we do agree strongly on and supporting our community of Henrico and he has been a friend and someone who I can call on for help did just a couple weeks ago and he's always there and I

[00:42:49] think he is he's just such a great guy and I'm glad he's here with us today so if we could give him a warm Senate welcome thank you senator for that introduction and welcome to former senators stosh thank you so much for joining us. Thank you for being retired. We know how important especially the work with the GRASP is that you have been doing helping so many students all across the Commonwealth. Senators I ask that we give the warm welcome of the

[00:43:19] Senate to our former colleague Senator Walter Stosh. We've now arrived in the time of our morning hour when we have the honor of welcoming our distinguished guests who are joining us today in our gallery. I give my daily reminder about our procedure. A senator will first rise and offer the introduction for his or her guests in the gallery and then I will offer the welcome of the Senate. I

[00:43:58] ask that we all hold our applause until I've had the opportunity to deliver the welcome from the Senate. The chair recognizes the senator from Hampton. thank you madam president I rise for an introduction the senator has the floor thank you madam president I'm grateful for the presence of Reverend Nathan Cecil who offered the invocation this morning he is a senior pastor Fox Hill Road Baptist Church in Hampton and he is joined today by three of his four children please extend to Reverend Cecil and his children the warm welcome of

[00:44:34] the Senate thank you senator for that introduction and thank you again to Reverend Cecil and to the children who are joining you this morning. If you will also stand with your dad, we'd love to see you and acknowledge you. Thank you for being here to support your father. Thank you, Reverend, for the beautiful prayer and blessing that you offer to our Senate chamber this morning. We're delighted to have you and I hope you have a wonderful tour of the Capitol today as you visit us. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the

[00:45:08] Senate to the Reverend Nathan Cecil from Hampton and his children. The chair recognizes a senior senator from Virginia Beach. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for an introduction. The senator has the floor. Madam President, today I rise to introduce a very special group of visitors to our Capitol. Joining us in the gallery, we have four students from the Eastern Shore Community College as well as the President, Darrell Mims, Vice President, Ramsey O'Keeley, and

[00:45:48] and advisor Kentrell Walker. They're here as part of their educational journey and to witness the legislative process. These students represent the bright future of our Commonwealth and it's an honor to welcome them to Richmond. They are here to learn about how our state government works and I hope their visit will be both informative and inspiring. Madam President, I ask that we offer the warm welcome of the Senate as they explore the heart of Virginia's government and gain invaluable insight into the democratic process. Thank you senator for that introduction and if our representatives from the Eastern Shore will please stand

[00:46:26] thank you so much for for joining us we have a lot of visitors from our community colleges today we're so delighted that our students and colleagues from Eastern Shore are also here and wish you a very good day as you meet with your legislators and as you tour the Capitol. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to our students and representatives from the Eastern Shore Community College. The chair recognizes the senator from Botetourt.

[00:47:05] Thank you, Madam President. Arise for an introduction. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. It's my honor today to recognize a very special group visiting us in the Senate gallery. We have students, faculty, and leaders from the Virginia School for the Deaf and the Blind located in Stanton. Founded in In 1839, the Virginia School for the Deaf and the Blind has been serving students for more than 185 years.

[00:47:28] It's one of the oldest schools of its kind in the nation, and has long been a source of pride for the Commonwealth. Situated in the beautiful Shenandoah Valley, VSDB provides specialized education and support for students who are deaf, blind, and deaf and blind, equipping them with the tools, confidence, and independence they need to thrive.

[00:47:47] It's my great honor to serve on that Board of Visitors as the current chairman. Madam President, I believe you also have served on the Board of Visitors for the Virginia School for the Deaf and the Blind. Also, joining them in the gallery today is also their interim superintendent, Charity Warrigan, whose leadership continues the school's strong tradition of excellence and care.

[00:48:07] So, I hope that we can give them a warm welcome, and if you will indulge me for just a moment to be able to say to them. Thank you, Senator. Thank you for that introduction.

[00:48:29] and if our guests from the school for the deaf and blind will please stand we would be delighted to welcome you all thank you so much for being here I'm delighted that the senator from Badatat continues to serve on the board it was a board that I was very honored to serve on we know how critically important the work is in the school we know how much this school provides to its students and and we're delighted to have you visiting us here today. Senators, I ask that we give the very warm

[00:49:02] welcome of the Senate to our guests from the Virginia School for the Deaf and Blind. Thank you. The chair recognizes the senator from Norfolk. Thank you, Madam President. Thank you. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for an introduction. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President.

[00:49:32] I am pleased to recognize the college board members, staff, and students from Tidewater Community College, if they would please stand. They are here today and have their fearless leader with them, Dr. Marsha Constant, who is the sixth president of Tidewater Community College. She has been serving as president since January 2020. Under her capable leadership, the college is expanding enrollment growth in both transfer students and workforce training. More Virginians are getting trained, upskilled, uplifted, and all leading to job preparedness and career placement. TCC serves

[00:50:11] Southampton Roads with four campuses in Norfolk, Portsmouth, Chesapeake, and Virginia Beach. And as an alum, I can say I've taken classes on all four campuses. There's also six regional centers that they offer camp uh classes on as well tcc is the second largest of the 23 virginia community colleges enrolling over 24 000 students tcc's vision is to be the community's first choice for education opportunity partnership and innovation the college's mission is to provide

[00:50:48] collegiate education and workforce training to individuals of all ages helping them achieve their goals and contribute to the vitality of the regional and global community. This year TCC is now sponsored, is now a sponsored apprenticeship partner with Virginia Career Works. We are the first community college to obtain this credential and we seek to be the Commonwealth's leading agent in all apprenticeship programs. We train the students, we train the citizens of Southampton Roads and make force workforce readiness our primary objective.

[00:51:28] Madam President as a proud alumni I am proud to say that their motto from here go anywhere really does work. Would you please join me in giving them the warm welcome of the Senate. Thank you Senator for that introduction and welcome to our representatives from Tidewater Community College. As you can see your alumni go anywhere, and you have certainly have a proud alum right here in the Senate chamber. Thank you for all the work that you are doing. I was so delighted to meet with many of our students this morning, and we know that our students are

[00:52:06] striving and going to do remarkable things, so delighted to have you. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the representatives from Tidewater Community College. The chair recognizes the senator from Rockingham.

[00:52:27] Madam President, rise for an introduction. The senator has the floor. Among the other community colleges represented in the gallery we also have Blue Ridge Community College who is here visiting us today led by Dr. John Downey who's been a friend of mine for 25 maybe 30 years since our kids were in middle school together. Dr. Downey has done a wonderful job leading Blue Ridge Community College and he is accompanied by employees Ellen Ault and Bridget Baylor along with students who I had the pleasure of meeting with this morning one of whom

[00:53:07] wants to be a pediatric oncologist which I find unbelievably admirable another who wants to engage in our AI industry and make a lot of money and I salute them both for their endeavors and would ask you to welcome them to the Senate here today. Will our students and representatives from Blue Ridge please stand? There we are, I can see you right in the front row. Thank you so much for joining us and as we see it is our special honor to greet so many of our representatives from throughout the Commonwealth that are part of the

[00:53:46] Virginia Community College system. We're especially delighted by the work that's happening at Blue Ridge. Thank you for all of the innovative programs that you are introducing. And Senator, I have to claim friendship with the president myself. That goes back a couple of decades as well, so we are just delighted.

[00:54:07] We are delighted to have you all here. Senators, I ask that we give the very warm welcome of the Senate to the representatives and students from Blue Ridge Community College. The chair recognizes the senator from Charlottesville. I rise for introduction ma'am. The senator has the floor. Madam President, today is Community College Day I guess and I'm honored to announce

[00:54:44] that a group from Piedmont Virginia Community College which is in Albemarle County are here and and announcing superlatives I guess I would just tell the ladies and gentlemen of the Senate that about 25 years ago there was an article on the front page of the Wall Street Journal that listed the 20 best community colleges in the country. Only one of those community colleges was in Virginia. That was Piedmont Virginia Community College. So, Madam Chair, Madam President, I would appreciate it if you

would give them the warm greetings of the Senate. Thank you, Senator, for that introduction and will our representatives

[00:55:20] from Piedmont Virginia please stand. Thank you so much for joining us and the tremendous accolades that you continue to receive. Again, we have the privilege of having 23 outstanding community colleges in our system and we know the excellence that is going on in each of our institutions in Piedmont Virginia Community College. We're so proud of the work that you are all doing. Delighted to have you here today. Senators, I ask that we give the very warm welcome of the Senate to the representatives and the students from Piedmont Virginia

[00:55:54] Community College the chair recognizes the senator from milk Mecklenburg Thank you madam president I rise for an introduction the senator has the floor I actually have two introductions that I'm gonna put into one I have two very amazing community colleges here today I have Southside Virginia Community College and Danville Community College if you were both rise these are definitely two

[00:56:32] of the very best community college systems in the state and also see that we have chance Chancellor Dory with us if you'll stay in sir I'm not supposed to introduce him but we can't go without recognizing him Southside Virginia Community College proudly serves residents across more than 4,200 square miles including the city of Emporia and the counties of Brunswick Buckingham Charlotte Cumberland Greensville Halifax Lunenburg Mecklenburg not away in Prince Edward County. The college is dedicated to inspiring excellence, transforming lives, and contributing to the economic vitality of the diverse

[00:57:11] communities it serves. Representing SVCC today is an outstanding student, Kristen Scott. She's a nursing student from Freeman, Virginia. We are also honored to be joined by the president, Dr. Quentin Johnson, one of my favorite people on earth um along with members of his leadership team and we also have um the danville community college uh today with their um student advocates and president uh i won't call him the other dr

[00:57:45] johnson but he's uh dr cornelius johnson um he's got six students with him four committed staff members together together they stand united to share the college impact on the region and advocate for continued support of accessible high quality education for all. Danville Community College is a two-year institution for higher education under the statewide Virginia Community College system. DCC's service area includes the city of Danville, Pittsylvania County, and Halifax. Danville Community College is one of 23 colleges in the Virginia Community College system.

[00:58:21] The associate degree curricula of the college has been approved by the State Council of Higher Education for Virginia and I just have to say I heard some very amazing stories from the students that came today some of them are starting lives over from very difficult pasts we've got students that are just starting from from after high school we have some students that are starting over later in life like I did and I always share with them my story and how my

[00:58:59] slogan is all you need when you start over in life is God and community college and and in rural Virginia without our community colleges the opportunities for people to learn a trade and to learn so many higher education courses and fulfill their life's dreams would not be possible and most of these students have the guidance of their community college presidents

[00:59:33] and their staff that they learn high skills to get high paying jobs and to be able to stay in our communities and nothing's more important to rural Virginia than that so I want to commend their presidents and the outstanding job them and their staff does and say welcome to the students that have come today and thank you for all you do I hope we'll give them their warm welcome of the Senate thank you senator for that introduction and as you've heard from the very loving and generous introduction provided by the senator we

[01:00:09] are so incredibly proud of the work that is happening in each of our institutions our students are clearly remarkable students ready to lead the way in so many different professions. We're especially honored by the leadership that is provided in every institution and to our Chancellor we say thank you as well for your leadership for the entire Virginia Community College system. Senators I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the representatives from Danville Community College as well as Southside Virginia

[01:00:43] Community College. We are going to take a break from our morning hour and the chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax. Thank you, Madam President.

[01:01:06] Madam President, I move to suspend the rules and grant the privileges of the floor to certain distinguished persons. The question is, shall the rules be suspended and the privileges of the floor be granted to a distinguished person? All in favor of that motion will record their votes aye, those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote. Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 39, no 0. Ayes 39, no 0. The privileges of the floor are granted. The chair recognizes the senator from

[01:01:45] Charlottesville for the purpose of presenting a distinguished guest. Madam President, ladies and gentlemen of the Senate, for the third year in a row I have the privilege to introduce to the Senate the Outstanding Virginian, and this year we've got one of our brightest legal scholars probably of the last 50 or 60 years in Virginia. What an honor it is today to introduce the 2026 Outstanding Virginian, the Honorable J. Harvey Wilkinson III. Judge Wilkinson is an esteemed jurist that needs no introduction. From his service to our country in the United States Army, his commitment to students while a professor

[01:02:23] at the UVA Law School, his long tenure serving on the U.S. Court of Appeals for the Fourth Circuit, including as Chair Judge Wilkinson's dedication to service and his impact on the legal system is remarkable. J. Harvey Wilkinson is indeed the epitome of an outstanding Virginian, and we're fortunate to have him here with us today.

[01:02:45] Joining him here on the floor are his wife, Lassie, and his children Porter and Nelson and also our John B. Adams, Jr., Jay Adams, we've known for a long time, and James Rich, the president and vice president. I see Charlie Solheimer also from the Outstanding Virginians Committee in the gallery. We're joined by other Outstanding Virginian board members, friends, and colleagues, including our old friend and judge Steve Agee and judge Roger Gregory.

[01:03:23] I asked the clerk to read the resolution. - Senate joint resolution number 85, commending the Honorable J. Harvey Wilkinson III. Whereas the Honorable J. Harvey Wilkinson III, a highly admired legal educator and an esteemed jurist, who has served as a judge on the United States Court of Appeals for the Fourth Circuit since 1984, received the prestigious Outstanding Virginia Award in 2026.

[01:03:57] And whereas Harvey Wilkinson attended St. Christopher's School in Richmond and the Lawrenceville School in Lawrenceville, New Jersey. He continued his education at Yale University, where he was president of the Yale Political Union and a member of the St. Anthony Hall before graduating Phi Beta Kappa in magna cum laude in 1967. And whereas Harvey Wilkinson proudly served the Commonwealth and the nation as a company clerk in the United States Army Reserve in Charlottesville from 1968 through 1974

[01:04:31] and whereas in 1972 Harvey Wilkinson earned a law degree from the University of Virginia where he was a member of the order of the cough and the Virginia law review while attending law school he ran for a seat in the US House of Representatives but was ultimately unsuccessful and returned to his legal education and whereas harvey wilkinson made history when he was appointed by governor linwood holton as the first student to serve on the university of virginia board of visitors he

[01:05:05] was later awarded the thomas jefferson medal the highest outside award offered by the institution and whereas harvey wilkinson began his legal career in 1972 as a clerk for justice lewis f Powell Jr. of the Supreme Court of the United States. To this day he regards Justice Powell's measured and balanced approach to his job as a model of what a judge should be and whereas after his clerkship Harvey Wilkinson returned to the University of Virginia School of Law where he was a professor from 1973 to

[01:05:43] 1978 1981 to 82 and 1983 to 84 he taught federal courts constitutional law and criminal procedure and he cherishes the fact that many of his students have remained lifelong friends and whereas in 1978 Harvey Wilkinson became editor of the Virginian palette and was in charge of the editorial and op-ed pages he loved the tidewater region and relished opportunities to provide insights on important local issues and whereas under Harvey Wilkinson's leadership the

[01:06:23] newspaper opposed on environmental grounds an oil refinery in Portsmouth resisted the introduction of pari-mutuel betting in the Commonwealth and advocated for cooperation between tidewater localities in securing a fresh stable water supply and whereas in 1982 Harvey Wilkinson was selected by the Reagan administration to be a deputy assistant attorney general in the Civil Rights Division of the US Department of Justice he was subsequently appointed by President Reagan as a judge of the United States Court of Appeals for the

[01:07:00] Fourth Circuit on August 13th 1984 and he later served as a chief judge of the 4th Circuit from 1996 to 2003 and whereas Harvey Wilkinson's 41 year tenure on the 4th Circuit is the longest in the history of the court and his active service is a federal court of appeal his active service as a federal court of appeals judge is one of the longest in the history of the nation and whereas Harvey Wilkinson has served on the boards of the federal judicial center the James Madison Memorial Fellowship Foundation the Virginia

[01:07:37] Historical Society and Charlottesville's Tuesday evening concert series he is a member of the American Law Institute and one of the few federal judges to be selected as a fellow of the American Academy of Arts and Sciences and whereas Harvey Wilkinson also is the author of several books on political and judicial history and issues of public policy and constitutional theory among his books are a personal memoir a falling face reflections on the promise and failure of

[01:08:11] the 1990s 1960s and a romantic novel love at deep dusk a Pennsylvania story and whereas the rule of law is among those topics dears to Harvey Wilkinson's heart he has often expressed the hope that the judicial system would serve as a beacon of ordered Liberty and as an anchor of independence in the

most divisive of times and whereas Harvey Wilkinson is proud to be a citizen of Virginia and thankful for those who serve the Commonwealth not only in elective office but also in state agencies and on boards commissions and

[01:08:48] other civic organizations he holds high the Founding Fathers vision of the United States Constitution namely that judicial respect for the democratic authority of lawmakers will be reciprocated by an earned trust in the judicial branch as a faithful instrument of law interpretation and whereas Harvey Wilkinson lives in Charlottesville and enjoys the love and support of his wife Lossie their two children Nelson and Porter and three grandchildren Harvey Jay and Davis now therefore be it resolved by the Senate the House of

[01:09:24] Delegates concurring that the General Assembly hereby commend the Honorable J. Harvey Wilkinson III, winner of the 2026 Outstanding Virginian Award for his exceptional contributions to the Commonwealth and the United States, and be it resolved further that the Clerk of the Senate prepare a copy of this resolution for presentation to the Honorable J. Harvey Wilkinson III as an expression of the General Assembly's admiration for his integrity legal acumen commitment to excellence and deep dedication to public service senator

[01:10:04] i ask that you and our distinguished guest the honorable j harvey wilkinson join me on the dais

[01:10:12] for the presentation of the resolution i'm so delighted to see you thank you thank you i'm

[01:11:10] sorry i should have had you go on the other side judge wilkinson we are so delighted to have you here today and what an amazing record of public service, of personal accomplishments, and we are so honored to acknowledge you and recognize you today

[01:11:35] as the 2026 Distinguished Virginian. Congratulations. Thank you so much and I'm just so proud to be a Virginian and I'm so proud to be in the Virginia General assembly with all of its history and contributions to representative

[01:12:13] government and I respect so much the electoral mandate that the members of this body come with and I know that you respect the rule of law and what the judiciary stands for and it's I think in these divisive times I hope that the courts can earn your trust as straightforward bodies who do our best to get it right and play

[01:12:53] it straight and underscore the importance of a rule of law in this particular time in our country's history and thank you so very much and it's an honor for me simply to be here among you thank Thank you, Judge.

[01:13:21] The Senate will be briefly at ease.

[01:36:33] The Senate will return to order. We will return to the morning hour. The chair recognizes the senator from Isle of Wight. Thank you, Madam President.

[01:36:49] I rise for an introduction. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Today is my distinct honor this morning to introduce some very special guests from back in my home district. Join us in the gallery, the outstanding students and facilitators of the Isle of Wight Student Leadership Institute.

[01:37:04] The Institute is offered to high school juniors who reside in Isla White County because they've already demonstrated leadership, potential, academic commitment, and a desire to make a difference. Throughout the academic year, participants engage in hands-on learning experiences, focus on team

building, effective use of community resources, and strengthening and self-confidence, also developing a heart for service.

[01:37:23] Madam President, programs like this remind us why we do this work. These students are not just the leaders of tomorrow, they are the leaders already today. They're learning how to serve, how to listen, how to collaborate, and how to lead with integrity. I ask that the members of the Senate join me in welcoming the students and visitors from the Isla White Student Leadership Institute and extend the warm welcome of the Senate.

[01:37:42] Thank you, Senator, for that introduction, and thank you to our students for joining us. I know how special these leadership programs are, and I'm sure you've learned a lot just from interacting with your own Senator and having this opportunity to visit so many throughout the Capitol. I hope this has been a very productive experience for you.

[01:38:03] Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the Isle of Wight Student Chamber Leadership Institute. The chair recognizes the senator from Washington. Thank you, Madam President, I rise for an introduction.

[01:38:26] Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. In the gallery we have a group of students and faculty from Mountain Empire Community College and I ask that they would stand. All right and while they're here joining other groups from community colleges across the Commonwealth. Madam President, I think they pretty handily win the award for traveling the furthest distance today and that would be six hours from Big Stone Gap. So among them today is student Keegan Bentley who is here celebrating his 21st birthday with us here in Richmond. So I ask that we give them a warm welcome to the Senate. Thank you Senator for that

[01:39:05] introduction and happy happy 21st birthday. What a special way to celebrate it. So we're delighted to have you here and thank you for traveling all those hours to join us at the capitol we are so delighted to to have you i know about the excellent work that's happening at mountain empire so thank you for being here thank you for the representation certainly looking forward to visiting at some point soon senators i ask that we give the warm welcome of the senate to our representatives and students from mountain empire community college

[01:39:36] the chair recognizes the senator from richmond city madam president i rise for the purpose of an introduction the senator has the floor although we do not hold the distinction of traveling the farthest our community colleges here locally make a great impact i would like to madam president ask the students and faculty from bright point community college if they're in the gallery please stand bright point community college envisions a success story for every student

[01:40:13] Bright Point, which is seeing a nearly 12% increase in enrollment this spring, offers educational and workforce training opportunities that support the needs of 10 localities throughout Central Virginia and the Tri-City regions. Today, Bright Point students are visiting the state capitol with their college president, Dr. Bill.

[01:40:33] He's up top, and I think you know him, Madam President. They have been meeting with legislators and sharing their stories about the impact of Bright Point is having on their lives and the lives of all of Central VA's students. If you would, please extend a warm Senate welcome to Bright Point Community College.

[01:40:52] Thank you, Senator, for that introduction and welcome to Bright Point Community College. We know of the impacts that you are having throughout this region, appreciate greatly all the work that is happening there and thank you for bringing the students to join us and hope you have wonderful conversations with your representatives today. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the students and president of Bright Point Community College.

[01:41:18] The chair recognizes the senator from Tazewell. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for the purpose of introduction. Senator has the floor. Madam President, today we have with us in the gallery students and faculty from my alma mater, Southwest Virginia Community College, which is located in Tazewell County it's these students first visit to the General Assembly and we are proud to have such a great representation of young people from Southwest Virginia we thank the faculty and leadership including president dr.

[01:41:57] Clinton Hayes from Southwest Virginia to for bringing these students to Richmond so they may learn about their state government and see firsthand how the decisions made here impact their lives madam president please give them the warm welcome of the Senate. Thank you Senator for that introduction and you have traveled quite far as well so thank you for making that journey we're so delighted to have you here and certainly hoping that you have you're having wonderful conversations with representatives all throughout the day today. Thank you for the hard work that's going on at Southwest Virginia Community College. Senators I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate

[01:42:36] to our guest joining us from Southwest Virginia Community College the chair recognizes the senator from York thank you madam president I rise for an introduction the senator has the floor I am proud to introduce the delegation from my alma mater the Virginia Peninsula Community College as a as a

[01:43:13] graduate of Virginia's community college system I know firsthand that our community colleges are a cornerstone of opportunity across the Commonwealth connecting Virginians to education, careers, and economic mobility. We are joined today by President Porter Brannan along with students, faculty, and staff who represent a college making real progress. Over the past several years Virginia Peninsula has strengthened enrollment, retention, and completion while expanding access through new facilities, transfer pathways, dual

[01:43:48] enrollment and workforce training. VPCC plays a vital role in meeting Virginia's workforce needs, preparing students for high-demand fields such as maritime trades, healthcare, information technology, advanced manufacturing, and construction trades. Each year thousands of students earn credentials that allow them to move quickly into the workforce and contribute to the regional economy.

[01:44:16] Through strong partnerships with local employers and communities, VPCC is helping fill critical talent gaps and building a future ready workforce. 53% of students seeking higher education attend Virginia's community colleges and 80 plus percent of Virginia Community College graduates choose to stay and work in the Commonwealth. Their significance to our economic vitality is is clear please extend the warm welcome of the Senate to the delegation that is committed to changing lives and transforming communities the Virginia

[01:44:54] Peninsula Community College thank you senator thank you senator for that introduction and welcome to the Virginia Peninsula Community College again we hear about the remarkable work that's happening at your institution and one thing that is critically highlighted is that each of our community colleges has opportunities to develop areas of specialization that respond to the critical workforce needs

in the localities that they serve. So we are especially honored to have you all here joining the rest of the community college system representatives. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of

[01:45:34] the Senate to the Virginia Peninsula Community College. The chair recognizes the senator from Lynchburg. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for the purposes of an introduction. Senator has the floor. Not to be outdone, we also have a guest in the gallery, students from Central Virginia Community College located in Lynchburg, along with their president, Mr. Dr. John Capps, if y'all could please stand. CVCC serves the citizens of City

[01:46:12] of Lynchburg, Amherst, Appomattox, Bedford, and Campbell counties. Each year, CVCC educates more than 5,000 students through over 60 academic and workforce programs aligned with regional employer needs. Last year alone the college awarded nearly 1,400 academic credentials and 1,800 workforce credentials while also serving hundreds of dual enrollment and early college students. As a key driver of workforce readiness and economic growth in Central Virginia, contributing more than 200 and

[01:46:49] $24 million annually to the regional economy, CVCC was recently named by the Aspen Institute as one of the top 200 community colleges in the nation. Madam President, I hope the body will join me in giving the warm welcome of the Senate to the students and Dr. John Capps from Central Virginia Community College.

[01:47:11] Well thank you Senator for that introduction and congratulations to the distinguished honor of receiving the Aspen recognition. We're so proud of all of our community colleges and tremendously proud of the good work that's happening at Central Virginia Community College. I hope you've been having a productive day here and that you will continue to visit your state legislators as you continue forward in your individual careers. And senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the president of the senate to the president and students from

[01:47:47] central virginia community college senator from lynchburg yes madam president i rise for the purposes of another introduction the senator has the floor uh today we've had the pleasure here in the general assembly of being visited by members of leadership of the town of brookneil in campbell county and in the gallery today we've had their mayor and their uh town manager but in the gallery today we have Mr. Connor Francis who is a council member for the town of Brooke

[01:48:23] Neal and unfortunately madam president I hate to inform the body but he went to the senator from Franklin's alma mater the great college of Hampton Sydney located in Farmville Prince Edward County Virginia I would ask that the Senate please give the warm welcome of the Senate to mr. Connor Francis city councilman from the town of Brooke Neal thank you senator for that introduction and welcome to Councilman Connor Francis of the town of Brookneil. Thank you for your public service. Thank you for all that you do to represent the

[01:48:57] constituencies in the town of Brookneil. We know that these are very challenging days indeed, so thank you for for your commitment to doing that. Senators, I ask that we give the very warm welcome of the Senate to our Councilman from the town of Brookneil. The chair recognizes the Senate senior Senator from Loudoun. Good morning, Madam President. Madam President, I rise for the purposes of an introduction. The Senator has the floor. Madam President, today in the gallery we

[01:49:37] are honored to be joined by the members of the Loudoun County Democratic Committee. I can't see them, but I think they're up there. All right, perfect. Madam President, along with the Junior

Senator from Loudoun County, I am pleased to welcome our constituents engaged to the Virginia Capitol today. Their time, energy, and commitment to public participation play an important role and strengthening civic life in Loudoun County and beyond these volunteers work year-round to engage voters encourage voting turnout and support informed participation in our democratic process their efforts reflect a deep dedication to community involvement and to ensuring residents

[01:50:13] have a voice in the decisions that we make on their behalf in Richmond today they're here representing all eight magisterial districts of Loudoun County and are excited to have the opportunity to see firsthand the legislative process in action I thank them for their ongoing commitment to activism and for the many ways they contribute to our community I hope it is the pleasure of the Senate to join me in giving them a warm welcome thank you senator for that introduction and welcome to our representatives from Loudoun County Democratic Democratic Committee we're delighted to have you thank you for all of the work you do in advocating on so many issues that impact our communities

[01:50:49] and we know that you are represented well by the junior and senior senator from Loudoun. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the representatives from the Loudoun County Dems. The chair recognizes the Senator from Eastern Henrico. Madam President and members of the Senate, it is my honor to rise. For what purpose do you rise? I was so excited. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. It is my honor

[01:51:28] and privilege to welcome the students, faculty, staff, and alumni and supporters of the Virginia State University and I'd ask that they please stand. For 144 years, Madam President, Virginia State University has prepared leaders and strengthened the Commonwealth of Virginia. Founded on the principles of opportunity and excellence, Virginia State University has educated generations who have continued to serve in classrooms, communities, businesses, and public service across our nation. Madam President, our Commonwealth is indeed

[01:52:03] greater because of the Virginia State University. Today we also recognize an important milestone as we congratulate President McCullough Abdullah on 10 years of dedicated service to the Virginia State University. And Madam President, I would go even further and say quite frankly that service is also to our commonwealth and to this nation. His leadership has advanced the university's mission, strengthened success, and positioned Virginia State

[01:52:42] University for continued growth and impact. To the students here today, Madam President, your presence in this Capitol reflects the importance of civic engagement and leadership, and we are proud to welcome them. Madam President, on behalf of myself, on behalf of every elected and those serving in state government with an affiliation to Virginia State University, and even individuals like my seatmate who just want to show support and wear orange and blue, Madam President, I'd ask that you join me in giving

[01:53:21] Virginia State University the warm welcome of the State Senate. I thank the Senator for that introduction and welcome to our representatives our students from the Virginia State University. Thank you for joining us and congratulations President Abdullah for the remarkable anniversary. Your dedication, your continued service to empowering the students to making the university shine is certainly well recognized and so we thank you for the service and the devotion that you continue to show to this tremendous

[01:53:58] institution. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to our representatives and students from the Virginia State University. Is there any other business for the morning hour? The clerk will call the calendar. Senate

[01:54:32] calendar for Wednesday, February the 18th, 2026. Unfinished business Senate. Senate bill 27 has passed a house with a substitute the chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Prince William thank you madam president madam president asked if this bill go by temporarily without objection Senate bill 27 goes by temporarily Senate bill 74 has passed the house with a substitute the senator

[01:55:09] senior senator from Prince William thank you madam president madam president with the recommendation that the house substitute be rejected I move that the substitute be agreed to in speaking to the motion. Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Like usual, the House got some parts right and most of it wrong, and so we just need to reject it. So thank you, Madam President. With the recommendation that the substitute be rejected, the question is, shall the substitute from the House be agreed to? All in favor of that motion will record

[01:55:43] their votes aye. Those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted. Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 0, noes 39. Ayes 0, noes 39. The substitute is rejected. Senate Bill 337 has passed. Senate Bill 323

[01:56:21] has passed the house with the substitute. The senator from Eastern Fairfax. Thank you Madam President. With recommendation that we reject the house substitute, I move that we concur. Speaking of that motion. Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. House made a couple changes, I think, to the effective date of this, but I'm also told that there's another change that needs to be made to this bill that's been requested by the Attorney General's office, and so we need to put this thing in conference so that can happen in due course. So I would hope we could

[01:56:55] reject the committee substitute, the House substitute. With the recommendation that the House substitute be rejected, the question is, shall the Senate concur with the House substitute? All in favor of that motion will record their votes aye. Those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote?

[01:57:20] The clerk will close the roll. Aye zero, no's 39. Aye zero, no's 39. The House substitute is rejected. Senate Bill 337 has passed the House with a substitute. The chair recognizes the senior senator from Loudon. Thank you Madam President. Madam President I move that we reject the substitute in speaking to that motion.

[01:57:44] Senator has the floor. Thank you Madam President. Madam President this is a National Guard bill that is a different National Guard bill than the bill that we passed out of this body and and this bill just needs to end up over in conference and work through the differences Madam President. So Madam president with that I move that we reject the amendment with the recommendation that the house substitute be rejected the question is shall the Senate concur with the house substitute all in favor of the motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close

[01:58:23] the roll zero knows 39 I zero knows 39 the house substitute is rejected Senate bill 347 has passed the house with a substitute the senator from Western Henrico and president's goodbye for the day without objection Senate bill 347 goes by for the day Senate bill 425 has passed the house with a substitute

this senior senator from Henrico thank you madam president madam president with the recommendation the house substitute be rejected I move that steps to be

[01:59:01] agreed to and I'd like to speak to that senator has the floor thank you madam President, Madam President, the House substitute removes amendments made to this bill and committee that were agreed upon by all stakeholders. I think the House just hadn't had an opportunity to speak to those stakeholders at the time.

[01:59:19] And so I think they all agree on that side, that the bill that came over to them is the way it should be. And we're going to adjust the House bill accordingly. So I'll restate my recommendation. With the recommendation that the House substitute be rejected, the question is, shall the Senate concur with the House substitute?

[01:59:43] All in favor of that motion will record their votes, aye. Those opposed, no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Aye, zero.

[02:00:00] Nos, 38. Aye, zero. Nos, 38. The House substitute is rejected. Senate Bill 581, let's pass the House with a substitute. Senator from Central Fairfax. Thank you, Madam President. With the recommendation that the House substitute be rejected, I move that the House substitute be agreed to in speaking to that motion.

[02:00:21] Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Senate Bill 589 was a simple bill to include the Town of Vienna in the same requirements on developers for restoring tree canopy, but for some odd reason, the House decided they were going to put it into i'm so sorry i'm reading the wrong bill uh 581. um i have had a couple city charter and for some reason they just took everything out and kept one so i ask that we reject that with the

[02:00:55] recommendation that it be rejected the question is shall the senate concur with the house substitute all in favor of that motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote. Have all the senators voted. Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. I 0, noes 38. I 0, noes 38. The house substitute is rejected. Senate Bill 589 has passed the house with the substitute. The senator from Central Fairfax. Thank you,

[02:01:34] Madam President. With the recommendation that the house substitute be rejected, I move that the house substitute be agreed to and speaking to that motion. Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President Senate bill 589 it's regarding tree canopy for some reason the House decided they wanted to put it into a study and I was not aware of that so I asked that we reject the substitute with the recommendation that the house substitute be rejected the question is shall the Senate concur with the house substitute all in favor of that motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any

[02:02:13] Senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll 0 knows 38 I 0 knows 38 the house substitute is rejected returning to page 2 Senate bill 27 has passed the house with a substitute the senator from Eastern Prince William yes madam president madam president with the recommendation

[02:02:47] that it be rejected I ask that we concur on the house substitute speaking to the motion and speaking to that madam senator has the floor yes madam president there are a couple of changes that we

just need to review thoroughly before we can agree to it and so at this juncture we just ask that that we send conference. With the recommendation that the House substitute be rejected, the

[02:03:22] question is, shall the Senate concur with the House substitute? All in favor of the motion will record their votes aye. Those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. I 0, no's 38. I 0, no's 38. The House substitute is rejected senator from Eastern Fairfax regular calendar has

[02:03:58] bill on third reading has bill 29 budget bill amends and reenacts chapters 725 the acts of assembly of 2025 which appropriates public revenues for two years ending respectively on June 30th 2025 and June 30th 2026 reported from committee on finance and appropriations with senate amendments substituted for house amendments the senator from portsmouth thank you madam president madam president i move the house

[02:04:30] bill 29 go by for the day without objection house bill 29 goes by for the day uncontested calendar house bills on second reading the senator from eastern fairfax president i move that all the house bills on second reading and the uncontested and regular calendars pages six through eight House Bill 799 through 550 that the rules be suspended in the second constitutional reading of the titles be dispensed with. The question is, shall the rules be suspended in the second reading of the titles of the House bills on the uncontested and regular calendars,

[02:05:04] pages 6 through 8, House Bill 799 through House Bill 550 be dispensed with? All in favor of that motion will record their votes aye, those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted. Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 38, noes 0. Ayes 38, noes 0. The reading of the titles is dispensed with. Senator from Eastern Fairfax.

[02:05:37] But ask that all those bills go by for the day. The question is, shall the house bills now on the uncontested and regular calendars, now on their third reading, go by for the day? All in favor of that motion will say aye those opposed no the ayes have it the bills will go by for the day senator from eastern fairfax inquiry the clerk does that complete today's calendar yes sir great we will return briefly to the morning hour the chair recognizes the senior senator from virginia

[02:06:17] beach thank you madam president i rise for an announcement i'm sorry i rise for an introduction the senator has the floor madam president i rise for an introduction today i have the pleasure of introducing the members of frank w cox high school young republicans club a student organization that has quickly become one of the most active and engaged groups at their school founded just this past september and led by president club president and former senate page sam savino the club has already grown to include more than 70 members who regularly

[02:06:56] attend meetings this has earned them recognition as the fastest growing club at their school beyond meetings and discussions these students are actively involved in community service projects it's encouraging to see such young students take an active interest in their communities and in civic life in the commonwealth and we are pleased to welcome them here today madam president please join me in offering the club president sam savino former page and the members of of cox w i'm sorry frank w cox high school young republican club the warmest welcome

[02:07:33] of the senate thank you senator for that introduction and welcome back to our senate page sam sedino thank you so much for all that you are doing and you've clearly taken the skills and the knowledge

that you gained uh as serving as senate page and have applied it in such an admirable way. Thank you for the leadership and thank you to our students who are joining us. Clearly the the work is going on in community service and making sure that you are understanding what issues and concerns are impacting communities and you are sharing and adding your voice to such important

[02:08:13] conversations. Senators I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to former Senate page, now President Sam Sedino, as well as the club that he leads, the Frank W. Cox High School Young Republican Club. Is there any other business to come before the Senate?

[02:08:42] The Senator from King George. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for a brief point of personal privilege. The Senator has the floor. I know everybody's groaning, but this is important, Madam President. I don't know, I'm guessing everybody in here knows about about a month or ago. There was a six-foot pipe in Maryland that burst that took sewage to DC water. At this point in time, we've got about 250 million gallons of raw sewage. Well, I'm going with the numbers that

[02:09:17] they're putting out. I would suspect it is a lot more than that, but officially it's only 250 million gallons. And it's a whole lot different than when it actually goes into the treatment facility and these combined overflows and it's mixed with water this is undiluted straight raw sewage going into the potomac and if that wasn't bad enough they say that the levels of e.coli are a thousand times higher than what's safe for human contact and that's pretty scary MRSA a whole lot of other

[02:09:54] things but what was the most disheartening to me is this people have been contacting me and I've told them to go to the Virginia Department of Health, because that's the agency responsible for public health in the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[02:10:11] So one of my constituents did. And put this in perspective, I mean, the Potomac River is up, Alexandria, right on down. There are hundreds of thousands, if not more, if not in the millions, who live either on the river or on tributaries up in it.

[02:10:32] So one of my constituents contacted the Virginia Department of Health, and their response was, thank you for your inquiry. This spill occurred with the details of it, but we really don't do anything about it. This is a responsibility of Maryland and D.C. water.

[02:10:49] And, Madam President, I've got to tell you, I've got a very strong letter going to them today in DEQ, because if we can't rely on the Virginia Department of Health and the Department of Environmental Quality, to do water tests sampling figure out what we should or shouldn't be doing along this river and all the tributaries we're in bad shape and i fear right today we're in bad shape so i hope you all

[02:11:23] will all join me in trying to move them to do what's necessary to protect our citizens first and foremost and then i think as a body a general assembly we need to look at how we need to deal with this someone told me they saw it on the national news last night and it is in it's been dubbed the worst environmental disaster in united states history and i understand things happen and accidents happen and i and i get all that but what's important to me is the response to it

[02:12:00] and how are we going to deal with this how are we going to protect public health how are we going to fix it how are we going to clean it up and for those of us who live and get the dc market in television, it doesn't seem like anybody's taking this too seriously, and others can correct me if I'm wrong. It's just sort of, oh, it happened, we'll figure it out, it's going to take another nine months to fix it. But right

now, we have a lot of Virginia citizens whose health is seriously at risk, not to mention our seafood market, and I know a lot of people enjoyed those oysters today,

[02:12:37] and I hope they didn't come from the Potomac, Madam President. Thank you, Senator. The senior Senator from Virginia Beach. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for two quick announcements.

[02:12:54] The Senator has the floor. Madam President, just wanted to make sure everybody has received their invite to the Virginia General Assembly's Military and Veterans Caucus 15th Annual Military Appreciation Night, Thursday, February 19th from six to eight at the Virginia War Memorial.

[02:13:12] Looks kind of like this, but just want to make sure everybody's seen this and know that everybody's invited and madam president secondly i'd like to announce the aviation caucus tomorrow morning at 8 a.m at uh sixth floor b conference room in the gab thank you thank you senator the senator from richmond city senator from richmond city madam president i rise for a point of personal privilege the senator has the floor um madam president as you know on yesterday um a tragedy struck richmond

[02:13:49] city again uh 23 year old hope cartwright a gifted journalist an associate editor of virginia living magazine tragically lost her life due to a hit and run accident hope had a remarkable way of shining a light on her community with warmth curiosity and genuine care qualities that remind us why safety and well-being of every virginian matters every year hundreds of virginians are killed while walking highlighting the urgent need for legislation that prioritizes pedestrian safety

[02:14:25] and multi-modality just as hope amplified the stories of our towns and neighborhoods we must ensure the people who live work and walk in them can do so safely protecting protecting pedestrians is not just about streets it's about preserving the heart and spirit of our communities and And regardless of your zip code, regardless of where you live, no one should lose their life doing the one thing that so many of us have enjoyed since we were two and three years old, and that's walking, Madam President.

[02:14:58] So I hope that we would move as a body to find a legislative answer, a legislative fix to ensure that our family and friends, co-workers and loved ones do not lose their life in such a preventable tragedy.

[02:15:15] Thank you, Madam President. Thank you, Senator. The Senator from Central Fairfax. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for a point of personal privilege. The Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Today is the first day of Ramadan, so I just wanted to briefly say a couple of words.

[02:15:34] As we enter the blessing month of Ramadan, Muslims across the world begin a daily fast from dawn to sunset. From before the sun rises until it sets, we refrain from food and drinking, not simply as an act of discipline, but as an act of faith, reflection, and empathy.

[02:15:53] Ramadan is a time to refocus our hearts, strengthen our characters, and remember those who struggled with hunger every day. Each evening at sunset, we gather for Iftar, the meal that breaks the fast. traditionally we begin with dates and water and share a meal with family friends neighbors and anyone who wishes to join but iftar is more than just food it's about gratitude generosity and community Ramadan also teaches us that while we may fast individually we grow spiritually together it reminds us that our differences are not barriers but invitations to learn from one another to

[02:16:32] sit at the same table and to build a deeper understanding. So with that, with that, Delegate Sam Rasul and I would like to warmly invite each and every one of you to join us at our Naftar reception next Wednesday, February 25th.

[02:16:50] And each and every one of you should have received an invitation in your inbox and we will circulate that. So we hope that you can join us, share a meal with us, and come together on Wednesday, February 25th at 5:45 at the Commonwealth Strategy Group's place.

[02:17:10] Thank you, Madam President. Thank you, Senator. The Clerk will report any announcements on the desk. Today, Wednesday, February 18th, the Committee for Courts of Justice will meet 30 minutes after adjournment, Senate Room A, GAB.

[02:17:30] The Committee on General Laws and Technology will meet 30 minutes after adjournment in Senate Room B, GAB. Tomorrow Thursday, February 19th, the Finance and Appropriations Subcommittee on Health and Human Resources will meet at 7:30 a.m. in the Senate Finance and Appropriations Room, 13th Floor, GAB.

[02:17:51] The Hampton Roads Caucus will meet at 7:30 a.m. in the House South Conference Room, 700A GAB. The Committee on Education and Health will meet at 8:30 a.m. in Senate Room A of the GAB. The Democratic caucus will meet at 11:15 a.m. in Senate Room 1 of the Capitol. The Republican caucus will meet at 11:30 a.m. in Senate Room 2 of the Capitol. The Senator from Eastern Fairfax. Madam President, rise for announcement. Senator has the floor. Two things. Number one, I would ask that

[02:18:27] members of the courts of justice committee try to meet 15 minutes after we adjourn we mostly have that half cognates and and it's a little bit of new stuff but the sooner we get out of it the better and this is the second thing madame president i would just ask if everybody could we're moving into this phase when these house amendments start to come over if everybody could please review your procedure cards to make sure we make the correct motions uh there's a specific series of motions you're supposed to make me to make sure we make them correctly and follow the process. Thank you, Madam President. The chair recognizes the senator from

[02:19:04] Portsmouth. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I move that the Senate do now adjourn until 12 noon tomorrow. The question is, shall the Senate adjourn until 12 noon tomorrow? All in favor of that motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The ayes have it. The motion is agreed to. The Senate stands adjourned until 12 noon tomorrow.

[02:19:25] Be sure to stay connected with live sessions, catch up on past meetings, and explore our full

[02:20:06] archives anytime on the Senate of Virginia's YouTube channel.

